

XML

2.1 Introduction

XML is all over the place these days, whether you're checking out an RSS or Atom feed, or using Microsoft Office 2007's new DOCX format. The reason for its popularity stems from the fact that it is an open standard that's highly extensible and has a wide range of tools and techniques available for processing it.

One thing you should know about XML is — by itself, it doesn't define a language. Instead, it's a specification of how one may create a language. It's very flexible, and can be used to represent almost any kind of data, as such it is a perfect candidate for data transfer over the internet. As long as the data follows the XML specification, the creator can be sure that any tool capable of processing XML will be able to decode it.

Over time, many data formats have been lost as developers did not document how data structures are stored within a file. XML is plain text and hence human readable. Therefore, such a problem is eliminated, and data in most cases documents itself. Let's look at a common XML format called RSS.

```
<?xml version="1.0"?>
<rss version="2.0">
  <channel>
    <title>
      Liftoff News
    </title>
    <link>
      http://liftoff.msfc.nasa.gov/
    </link>
    <description>
      Liftoff to Space Exploration.
    </description>
```